

Phoenix Rising: A City Built on Water & Ambition



Figure 1: Postcard of Phoenix, AZ in 1995

In the summer of 1997, Phoenix stands as America's sixth-largest city, a sprawling desert metropolis where ancient irrigation channels flow beneath interstate highways, and where FBI field agents navigate a complex landscape of organised crime, political corruption, and explosive growth. This is a city where Hohokam engineering marvels enabled modern urban development, where frontier justice gave way to federal investigations, and where the confluence of Mexican cartels, Italian-American crime families, and ambitious politicians creates a uniquely challenging environment for law enforcement.

From its origins as an agricultural settlement rising literally from the ruins of a vanished civilisation, Phoenix has always been a city defined by audacious visions and the water needed to sustain them. By 1997, those visions have transformed a desert valley into a major American metropolis, but the same growth that created opportunity has also attracted criminal enterprises that federal agents must confront daily.

Ancient Foundations: The Hohokam Legacy (1-1450 AD)

The Phoenix story begins not with European exploration or American pioneering, but with one of North America's most sophisticated pre-Columbian civilisations. The Hohokam people, whose name derives from a Pima¹ word meaning "those who have gone", created the largest prehistoric irrigation system in the Western Hemisphere—a network of 135 miles of precisely engineered canals that sustained the largest native population north of Mexico City.

From their emergence around 1 AD through their mysterious disappearance circa 1450, the Hohokam demonstrated an engineering mastery that would later inspire American settlers. Their canals, carved through solid caliche² with stone tools, maintained gradients of just one to two feet per mile while directing Salt and Gila River water across 250,000 acres, supporting large villages and intensive agriculture in the desert. These sophisticated waterworks also enabled extensive trade networks reaching from the Pacific Coast to central

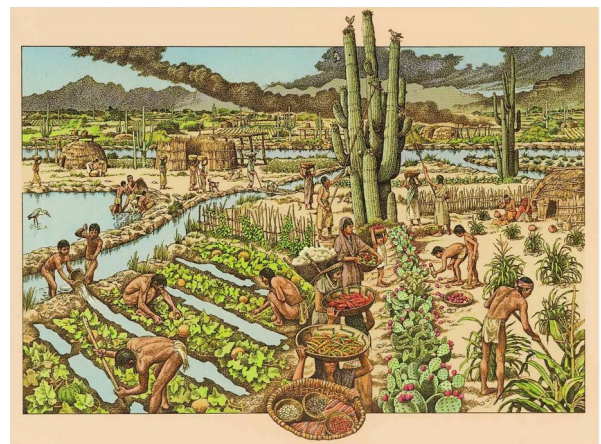
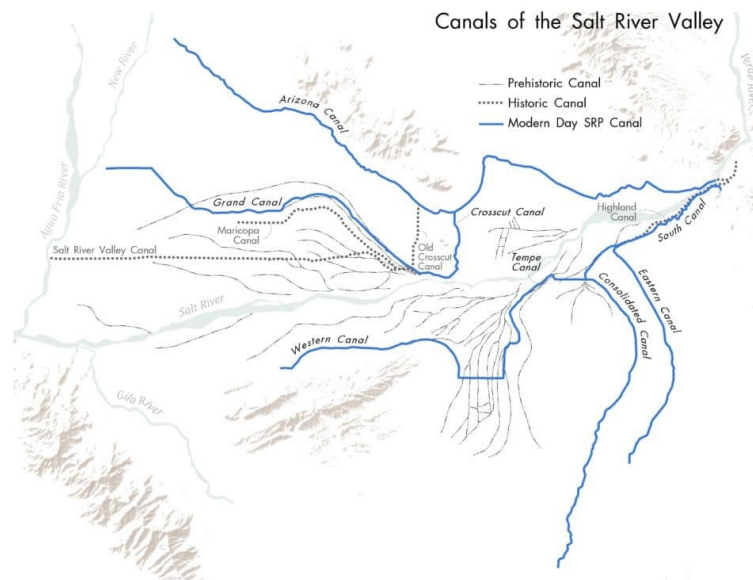


Figure 2: Artist's impression of Hohokam culture featuring extensive irrigation canal system

- 1 Native American language belonging to the Uto-Aztecan language family and spoken by the Pima people (also called the Akimel O'odham) who live primarily in Arizona. The Pima people lived in the same general area as the Hohokam civilisation. Pima is still spoken today, though like many indigenous languages, it has far fewer speakers than in the past.
- 2 A hardened layer of soil that forms in arid and semi-arid regions when water evaporates from the top soil, causing calcium carbonate and other minerals to cement together soil particles, creating a rock-like layer beneath the surface.

Mexico, and population centres that dwarfed anything European colonists would establish for centuries. Portions of those canals still lace central Phoenix; some were later re-excavated and incorporated into the modern water system, and their remnants are interpreted at the city's S'edav Va'aki (formerly Pueblo Grande) Museum near Sky Harbor.

The Hohokam's sudden disappearance around 1450 remains one of the Southwest's great mysteries. Archaeological evidence suggests a confluence of disasters: a great drought in the years 1276-99, devastating floods that damaged canal systems, possible warfare, and soil depletion from intensive agriculture. Their abandoned canal network lay dormant for over 400 years, waiting for another civilisation bold enough to attempt desert agriculture on such a massive scale.



Colonial Shadows: Spanish and Mexican Periods (1539-1848)

Spanish colonization largely bypassed central Arizona, focusing instead on the silver mines and missions of southern regions. The 1540-1542 Coronado expedition³ may have passed through southeastern Arizona, but found no cities of gold to justify permanent settlement. When Father Kino⁴ established missions beginning in 1687, Apache resistance and the region's isolation limited Spanish influence to areas around present-day Tucson.

The Mexican period⁵ (1821-1848) brought little change to the Salt River Valley. Central Arizona remained a dangerous frontier where Apache raids discouraged settlement, and the new Mexican government exercised minimal control over its northern territories. The valley that would become Phoenix remained largely uninhabited except for scattered Native American communities—Akimel O'odham (Pima) and Tohono O'odham (Papago) peoples who maintained small-scale agriculture using simplified versions of ancient Hohokam irrigation techniques.

This colonial neglect proved fortuitous. When American territorial authority arrived with the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo in 1848⁶, the Salt River Valley remained an essentially blank slate, free from established Spanish or Mexican land grants that complicated settlement elsewhere in the Southwest.



Figure 3: Ancient Hohokam irrigation canal in modern-day Phoenix

Territorial Foundations: The Swilling Vision (1848-1912)

3 Francisco Vázquez de Coronado (1520-1554): Spanish conquistador and explorer who led a large expedition from what is now Mexico to present day Kansas in 1540-1542.

4 Eusebio Chini (Spanish spelling: Kino) (1642-1711): Italian Jesuit, born in the Holy Roman Empire, who worked the last 24 years of his life the Primería Alta region, corresponding to modern-day Sonora in Mexico and southern Arizona, establishing missions and conducting exploration. Proved that the Baja California territory was not an island but a peninsula.

5 Mexico gained independence from Spain in 1821 after the Mexican War of Independence (1810-1821).

6 Treaty signed between Mexico and the United States ending the Mexican-American War (1846-1848) which forced Mexico to cede more than half of its territory to the U.S., including the present-day states of California, Nevada, Utah, most of Colorado, New Mexico, Arizona and Texas, plus a small part of Wyoming.

The transformation of central Arizona began with Civil War veteran Jack Swilling, a morphine-addicted entrepreneur whose vision would reshape the desert. In November 1867, while travelling through the Salt River Valley, Swilling recognized what Spanish colonists had missed: the remnants of Hohokam canals offered a blueprint for agricultural development. Within months, he had organised the Swilling Irrigating and Canal Company and begun excavating ancient waterways, with the goal of growing hay and grain for Fort McDowell and area mines.

Swilling's December 1867 expedition of seventeen miners from Wickenburg⁷ successfully diverted Salt River water by March 1868, harvesting their first crops that same year. The community that emerged around Swilling's homestead was briefly called "Stonewall" (after Confederate General Stonewall Jackson), but local intellectual Darrell Duppa suggested "Phoenix"—a city rising from the ruins of an ancient civilisation.

These early settlers quickly learned what the Hohokam had known centuries before: the Sonoran Desert's weather patterns could be both blessing and curse. The monsoon season, arriving each summer between June and September, brought desperately needed rainfall but also spectacular and dangerous haboobs—massive walls of dust that could engulf entire settlements in minutes, turning day to night and filling homes, wells, and irrigation channels with dirt. These towering dust storms, which could reach heights of several thousand feet and stretch for miles, became part of the valley's seasonal rhythm, teaching residents to watch the southern horizon for the telltale brown wall that signalled an approaching storm. Yet the monsoons also brought relief from the crushing summer heat and delivered precious water that, if properly captured and channelled, could supplement river irrigation.



Figure 4: Jack Swilling with his Apache ward Guillermo Swilling, ca. 1875

The territorial period established patterns that would define Phoenix for generations. The city's incorporation⁸ in 1881 coincided with railroad development that connected the isolated desert community to national markets, though train schedules often had to account for monsoon washouts and track-burying dust storms. By 1889, Phoenix had become Arizona's territorial capital, establishing its political centrality despite its environmental challenges. The Salt River Valley Water Users' Association, formed in 1903, secured federal funding for the massive Roosevelt Dam⁹ project that would not only guarantee the valley's water supply but also provide flood control against the violent monsoon floods that periodically devastated the valley.

The path to statehood proved contentious. Arizona's 1910 constitutional convention produced a progressive document that alarmed President Taft, particularly its provision for judicial recall¹⁰. Only after Arizona agreed to remove this provision did the territory become the 48th state on February 14, 1912. After gaining statehood, the provision was promptly restored—a defiant gesture that captured the independent spirit of a people who had learned to thrive in one of the continent's most challenging environments.

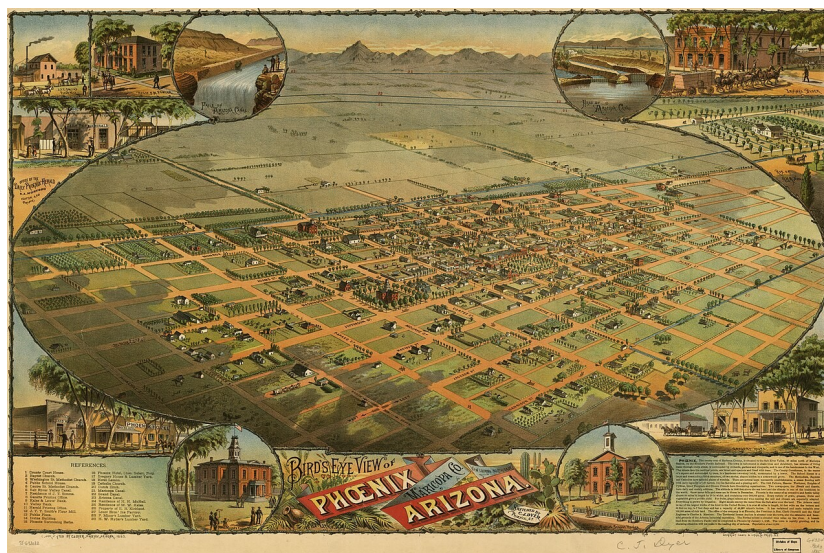


Figure 5: Aerial map of Phoenix in 1885

Building the Foundation: Early Statehood and the Five C's (1912-1941)

- 7 Mining town in Arizona founded 1863 by German prospector Henry (probably Anglicised from Heinrich) Wickenburg. It became an important mining centre in central Arizona during the 1860s.
- 8 A city becoming incorporated meant that it had gone through a legal process to become an officially recognised municipality with its own local government and legal powers.
- 9 Major concrete arch dam on the Salt River about 76 miles Northeast of Phoenix.
- 10 Mechanism that allows voters to remove judges from office through a direct election, essentially "recalling" them before their terms expire. In Arizona's 1910 constitution, this provision meant that if enough citizens signed a petition, they could force a recall election where voters would decide whether to remove a sitting judge. This was part of the broader Progressive Era movement that sought to give citizens more direct control over government. President William Howard Taft was alarmed by this provision because he believed it threatened judicial independence - a core principle of the American legal system.

Rails and reclamation made the village a city. Union Station opened in 1923, tying Phoenix into national rail networks and tourism circuits just as "Arizona climate" was being marketed to the nation.

Arizona's first decades as a state established Phoenix as the centre of an economy built on the "Five C's": Cotton, Cattle, Climate, Citrus, and Copper. Agriculture dominated the Salt River Valley, with alfalfa¹¹ giving way to cotton as the primary crop by 1920. The completion of Roosevelt Dam in 1911 and subsequent water projects enabled cultivation of over 250,000 acres (~1,000 km²), supporting nearly 4,400 farmers by 1921.

This agricultural prosperity attracted the city's first skyscrapers—the Heard Building (1920), Luhrs Building (1924), and Westward Ho hotel (1928)—while railroad connections made Phoenix a regional commercial centre. The economic boom also fostered cultural ambitions that would distinguish Phoenix from a mere agricultural depot. The Orpheum Theatre, opening in 1927 as a lavish vaudeville and silent film palace, brought metropolitan entertainment to the desert, its ornate Spanish Baroque Revival architecture declaring that Phoenix aspired to more than utilitarian growth. Two years later, Dwight and Maie Heard established the Heard Museum in 1929, dedicating it to preserving and presenting Native American culture and art—a prescient recognition that Phoenix's future would be enriched by honouring the civilisations that came before, particularly the Hohokam whose canal systems made modern Phoenix possible.

Sky Harbor Airport, established in 1929 alongside these cultural institutions, positioned the city for both the aviation age and the tourist economy that would eventually rival agriculture. Visitors drawn by the climate and health resorts could now experience not just desert air and citrus groves, but a city developing its own cultural identity.

The Great Depression tested but ultimately strengthened Phoenix's economic foundation. While copper mining collapsed from \$155 million in 1929 to just \$15 million in 1932, the valley's agricultural diversity and federal investment in water infrastructure enabled faster recovery than most American cities experienced. The Heard Museum and Orpheum Theatre, though struggling financially, survived through community support—early evidence of the civic pride that would characterize Phoenix's later cultural development. New Deal programs¹², while less documented in Phoenix than elsewhere, provided employment and infrastructure development that prepared the city for wartime transformation, including Works Progress Administration projects that improved both practical infrastructure and public spaces.

War and Transformation: The Military Catalyst (1941-1945)

World War II fundamentally transformed Phoenix from a regional agricultural centre into a major American city. The establishment of multiple military training facilities—Luke Air Force Base, Williams Field, Thunderbird Field, and Falcon Field—brought unprecedented federal investment and population growth to the valley.

Luke Air Force Base, established in 1941 and named for Phoenix native and World War I ace Frank Luke Jr., became the world's largest fighter pilot training facility. Thunderbird Field, financed by Hollywood investors including Jimmy Stewart and Henry Fonda, trained over 10,000 American, British, and Chinese pilots. The presence of these installations attracted defence contractors including Goodyear Aircraft, Garrett Corporation, and Allison Steel, establishing Phoenix as a centre for military aviation and aerospace manufacturing.

The war years brought dramatic demographic changes that would reshape the city's character. Military personnel from across the nation experienced Phoenix's winter climate and desert environment, with many returning after the war with their families. German and Italian prisoners of war, housed in local camps, sometimes chose to remain after 1945. This influx of newcomers, combined with continued federal military presence, created the foundation for Phoenix's post-war boom.

The Air-Conditioned Miracle: Post-War Explosion (1945-1960s)

The fifteen years following World War II witnessed Phoenix's transformation from a regional city of 120,000 residents to a major metropolis approaching half a million. The widespread adoption of air conditioning in the 1950s proved as crucial as water development had been in earlier decades, making year-round comfortable living possible in the Sonoran Desert¹³.

Phoenix's population quadrupled between 1945 and 1960, while the city expanded from 17 to 190 square miles through aggressive annexation policies. This growth was carefully cultivated through developer-friendly policies that encouraged low-density, automobile-centric suburban development. The postwar building wave remade the map: Maryvale emerged on the west side, Scottsdale to the Northeast, and the East Valley towns along the old highway grew into a continuous metropolitan fabric. The opening of Sun City in 1960—Del Webb's planned retirement community that attracted over 100,000 visitors on its opening weekend—demonstrated Phoenix's emergence as a destination for American retirees.

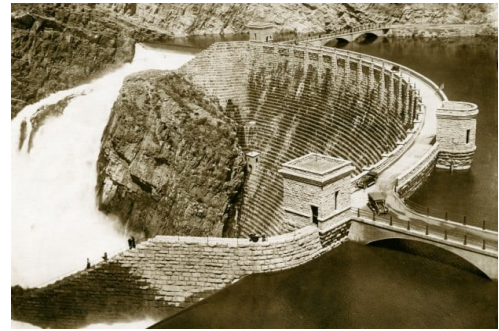


Figure 6: Roosevelt Dam in 1915 – four years after its completion

¹¹ A perennial flowering plant in the legume family, commonly grown as a forage crop for livestock.

¹² Series of wide-ranging economic, social, and political reforms enacted by President Franklin D. Roosevelt between 1933 and 1938 in response to the Great Depression.

¹³ The Sonoran Desert is a large (~260,000 km²) desert ecosystem located in the southwestern United States and northwestern Mexico. It's one of the four major North American deserts and is known for its distinctive biodiversity and iconic plant life.

This sprawling growth pattern demanded new transportation infrastructure, but Phoenix's relationship with freeways would prove more contentious than in many American cities. While other southwestern metropolises eagerly embraced interstate highways, Phoenix became embroiled in what would become known as the Papago Freeway fight—one of the most significant "freeway revolts" in American history. The proposed Interstate 10 route through central Phoenix, particularly the section that would cut through Papago Park and established neighbourhoods, sparked fierce opposition from residents who feared the destruction of communities and parkland. The controversy, beginning in the early 1960s, would rage for decades, making Phoenix one of the last major cities to complete its interstate connections and shaping a more sceptical local attitude toward infrastructure that prioritized automobiles over neighbourhoods.

Economic diversification accompanied demographic expansion despite these infrastructure battles. Manufacturing employment jumped from 49,000 in 1960 to 183,000 by 1985, driven by high-technology companies including Motorola, Hughes Aircraft, Honeywell, and IBM. Tourism became the city's third-largest industry, capitalizing on year-round sunshine and resort development. Most significantly, the systematic conversion of agricultural land to residential and commercial development established the sprawling, suburban character that would define modern Phoenix—a pattern that made the freeway disputes even more critical, as the low-density development depended entirely on automobile transportation.

This explosive growth heightened awareness of the valley's water limitations. While the Salt River Project dams had secured local water supplies, civic leaders recognized that sustained growth required access to Colorado River water. Years of political manoeuvring culminated in 1968 with federal authorisation of the Central Arizona Project¹⁴, a massive aqueduct system that would eventually deliver Colorado River water 336 miles across the desert to Phoenix, Tucson, and agricultural areas between. Though construction would take decades, the CAP's authorisation assured developers and residents that Phoenix's water future was secure, unleashing even more aggressive expansion in the decades to follow.

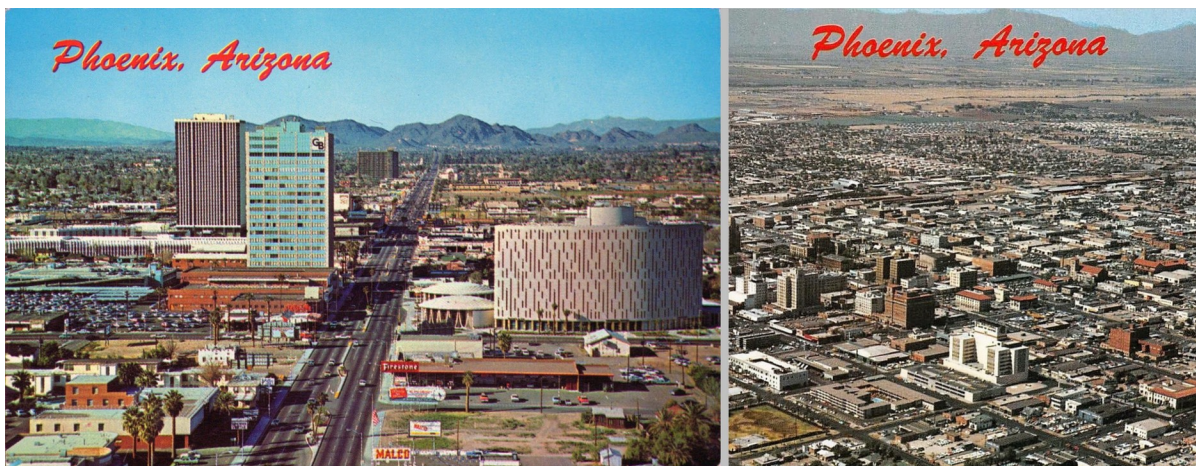


Figure 7: Postcards of Phoenix, 1950s

Shadows in Paradise: The Emergence of Organised Crime (1950s-1970s)

Phoenix's rapid growth and "open territory" status—no single crime family claimed exclusive control—attracted organised criminal enterprises from across the nation. Joseph "Papa Joe" Tocco, brother of a Chicago Heights capo, established significant operations throughout the 1950s and 1960s, coordinating bookmaking, loan sharking, and later narcotics trafficking. Unlike cities dominated by single crime families, Phoenix became a neutral ground where various organisations could operate, creating complex jurisdictional challenges for law enforcement.

The city's emergence as a major money laundering and land fraud centre earned it the nickname "Tainted Desert." Real estate speculation, fuelled by rapid growth and loose regulatory oversight, created opportunities for massive fraudulent schemes. One of the most notorious cases involved the June 2, 1976 assassination of Arizona Republic investigative reporter Don Bolles, and marked a watershed moment in Phoenix's relationship with organised crime. Bolles, who had spent years investigating connections between organised crime, land fraud, and political corruption, died eleven days after a car bomb exploded outside the Clarendon Hotel. His final story, published posthumously, exposed systematic corruption involving contractor Max Dunlap and controversial businessman Kemper Marley Sr. The murder shocked Arizona and triggered the largest collaborative journalism investigation in American history. Investigative Reporters and Editors, formed in response to Bolles's death, sent dozens of journalists to Phoenix to continue his work, creating the Arizona Project. Their reporting revealed extensive connections between organised crime figures, land developers, and political leaders, involving eleven companies with losses exceeding \$50 million. The Arizona Project led to eighteen federal indictments and established a tradition of aggressive investigative journalism that would influence Arizona politics for decades.

14 Not to be confused with the journalistic Arizona Project investigation, mentioned below.



Figure 8: Investigative journalist Don Bolles (left) and the aftermath of the car bomb that killed him.

The Bolles case remains officially unsolved, despite convictions of Dunlap and associate James Robison (later overturned). For FBI agents operating in Phoenix, the case represents both the dangers of investigating organised crime and the importance of protecting journalists and witnesses in high-stakes federal investigations.

Political Upheaval: Scandal and Reform (1980s-1990s)

The 1980s and early 1990s brought unprecedented upheaval to Arizona—a period of political scandals, environmental crises, and infrastructure battles. The era began with both promise and peril: while Arizona achieved crucial victories in water management with the 1980 Groundwater Management Act, the savings and loan crisis¹⁵ was already beginning to devastate the state's financial sector.

Phoenix businessman Charles Keating Jr.'s theft of over \$1 billion from Lincoln Savings depositors spawned the infamous "Keating Five" corruption case, with U.S. Senators Dennis DeConcini and John McCain, among others, facing intense scrutiny for their relationships with Keating. The scandal tarnished Arizona's political reputation nationwide and presaged worse to come. Governor Evan Mecham's 1988 impeachment and removal for obstruction of justice and misuse of funds demonstrated how deeply instability had infected state government. His successor, Rose Mofford, provided temporary stability, but the governor's office remained troubled—Fife Symington III, who followed Mofford, would see his own tenure end in disgrace with a bank fraud indictment in June 1997¹⁶.

Perhaps most shocking was the 1991 AZSCAM operation, a massive FBI sting that caught ten percent of the state legislature on videotape accepting bribes from undercover agents posing as casino investors. Seven legislators, five lobbyists, and five others were indicted for accepting \$370,000 in bribes. The scandal forced comprehensive campaign finance reform and cemented Arizona's reputation as a state where political corruption ran deep.

Yet amid this turmoil, Arizona achieved crucial infrastructure victories that would define Phoenix's future. The Central Arizona Project, authorised in 1968 after decades of political battles, finally began delivering Colorado River water to the Valley in 1985. By 1993, the massive concrete aqueduct stretched complete across 336 miles of desert, allowing Phoenix to reduce its dependence on overtaxed aquifers that had caused land subsidence throughout the valley. The 1980 Groundwater Management Act had already mandated that new subdivisions demonstrate a 100-year water supply, establishing Phoenix as a national leader in desert water conservation even as developers chafed at the restrictions.

The same year water began flowing through the CAP, another long-fought battle reached its conclusion. On August 10, 1990, the Papago Freeway's Deck Park Tunnel opened to traffic, completing the final segment of Interstate 10 and ending Phoenix's three-decade "freeway revolt." The celebration—attended by Governor Mofford, Senators DeConcini and McCain (both soon to be embroiled in the Keating scandal), and 100,000 curious residents during a three-day open house—marked Phoenix as the last major American city to



Figure 9: CAP aqueduct snaking through the Arizona desert.

15 A national financial crisis which involved the failure of approximately a third of the savings and loan associations (S&Ls or thrifts) in the U.S. between 1985 and 1995. These thrifts were banks that historically specialised in fixed-rate mortgage lending. The total cost of the collapses to U.S. tax-payers was \$124 billion. The crisis was the nation's largest-ever financial scandal, possibly contributing to the 1990's recession.

16 Governor Symington was subsequently convicted in September 1997, however, this conviction was overturned on appeal in 1999, and he received a presidential pardon from President Bill Clinton in January 2001.

complete its interstate connection. McCain joked, quoting Glen Campbell, "you can get there a lot earlier now," but the freeway's completion came at tremendous cost: entire neighbourhoods like Garfield had been bisected and destroyed during the decades of planning and construction delays.

Environmental challenges compounded the political chaos. Phoenix had been ranked pretty high for air pollution in recent years, with the city struggling to meet federal standards for ozone and particulate matter throughout the 1980s and 1990s. The summer of 1990 delivered a stark warning about the desert's limits when temperatures hit 122°F on June 26, briefly grounding flights at Sky Harbor because aircraft performance charts didn't account for such extremes. The city's rapid growth had created serious air quality problems that would persist through the decade, with Phoenix exceeded the Ozone standard dozens of days each year, particularly during the scorching summer months when heat and sunlight accelerated ground-level ozone formation.

This period also witnessed profound cultural transitions that reflected Phoenix's changing identity. The Phoenix Indian School, which had operated since 1891 as the only non-reservation Bureau of Indian Affairs school in Arizona, closed its doors for the last time in the spring of 1990. The school's closure—with enrolment having dropped from 638 students in 1985 to just 80 in its final year—marked the end of a controversial century of federal Indian education policy. Its 160-acre campus in the heart of Phoenix would eventually become Steele Indian School Park, but in the early 1990s it sat vacant, a haunting reminder of the federal government's complex and often tragic relationship with Native peoples.

Downtown Phoenix's cultural landscape was also in flux. The historic Orpheum Theatre, which had opened in 1929 as the city's grandest entertainment venue, had been purchased by the City of Phoenix in 1984 after years of decline. The city embarked on an ambitious \$14 million restoration that would take twelve years to complete. When the Orpheum finally reopened on January 28, 1997, with Carol Channing performing in "Hello, Dolly!"—just months before FBI agents would arrive for their summer operations—it symbolized both Phoenix's commitment to preserving its past and its aspirations for downtown renewal.

The era's surreal capstone came on March 13, 1997, when thousands of people across Arizona witnessed multiple unidentified lights that persisted for several hours. The Phoenix Lights, as the incident became known, prompted Governor Symington to hold a bizarre press conference where he joked that "they found who was responsible" and revealed an aide dressed in an alien costume. Years later, Symington would claim he had witnessed something "otherworldly" himself that night. While the lights were eventually attributed to A-10 aircraft training at the Barry Goldwater Range, the incident perfectly captured the strange convergence of military presence, government mistrust, and desert mysticism that characterized 1990s Phoenix—a city where political scandals, environmental crises, and UFO sightings could all compete for headlines.



Figure 10: On March 17, 1997, the so-called "Phoenix Lights" were observed for several hours by thousands of inhabitants of Arizona and Nevada, making it "perhaps the most widely witnessed UFO event in history". The lights were explained by Operation Snowbird, which involved several flights of A-10 Thunderbolt II aircraft belonging to the Air National Guard, out of Davis-Monthan Air Force Base in Tucson, launching flares and flying in formation over Phoenix. The incident caused a stir. Many Phoenixians did not believe the official explanation and the incident became a landmark case in UFO research and popular culture.

Border Complexities: Immigration and International Crime (1960s-1990s)

Phoenix's proximity to the Mexican border—approximately 150 miles—made it a natural centre for both legitimate immigration and criminal enterprises. The city's Hispanic population grew from a significant minority to nearly 40% by 1997, predominantly of Mexican origin, creating both cultural richness and social tensions.

Drug trafficking emerged as a major federal concern in the 1980s and 1990s. FBI investigations targeted Colombian cartel operations, resulting in major seizures including 2,033 kilos of cocaine in a single operation. Mexican cartels, particularly the Sinaloa, established increasing influence over trafficking routes through Phoenix to eastern markets, beginning in the early-to-mid 1990s.

The emergence of street gangs during this period created additional challenges for federal law enforcement. Hispanic gangs established in the 1960s and 1970s were joined by California-based Crips and Bloods in the late 1980s and early 1990s. Gang violence, officially acknowledged by city government only in 1989 despite a decade-long escalation, created an environment where federal agents needed to understand both traditional organised crime and emerging street-level criminal enterprises.

The Modern Metropolis: Phoenix in Summer 1997

By summer 1997, Phoenix stands as a testament to the American capacity for audacious reinvention—and to the complications that follow such ambition. The sixth-largest city in the United States emerged not from centuries of gradual growth but from a half-century sprint across the desert, powered by air conditioning, federal investment, aqueducts, and the kind of promotional optimism that convinced millions to trade established communities for a chance at desert living.

The threads of Phoenix's past converge in its present reality. Ancient Hohokam canals, re-excavated and incorporated into the modern water system, flow beneath freeways, some of which took three decades to complete. The Central Arizona Project's concrete channels snake across the desert like the canals that preceded it by a millennium, both monuments to the same truth: Phoenix exists because humans found ways to move water where nature never intended it to go. The city that Jack Swilling imagined rising from ancient ruins has indeed risen, though probably in ways he could have envisioned.

Downtown, the newly restored Orpheum Theatre and several museums stand as evidence of Phoenix's desire to preserve something of its past even as it races toward its future. Meanwhile, the vast campus of the former Phoenix Indian School sits empty, awaiting transformation into parkland—a hundred-year chapter of federal Indian policy closed, its complex legacy still being reckoned with by a city where Native American history is literally built into the foundation.

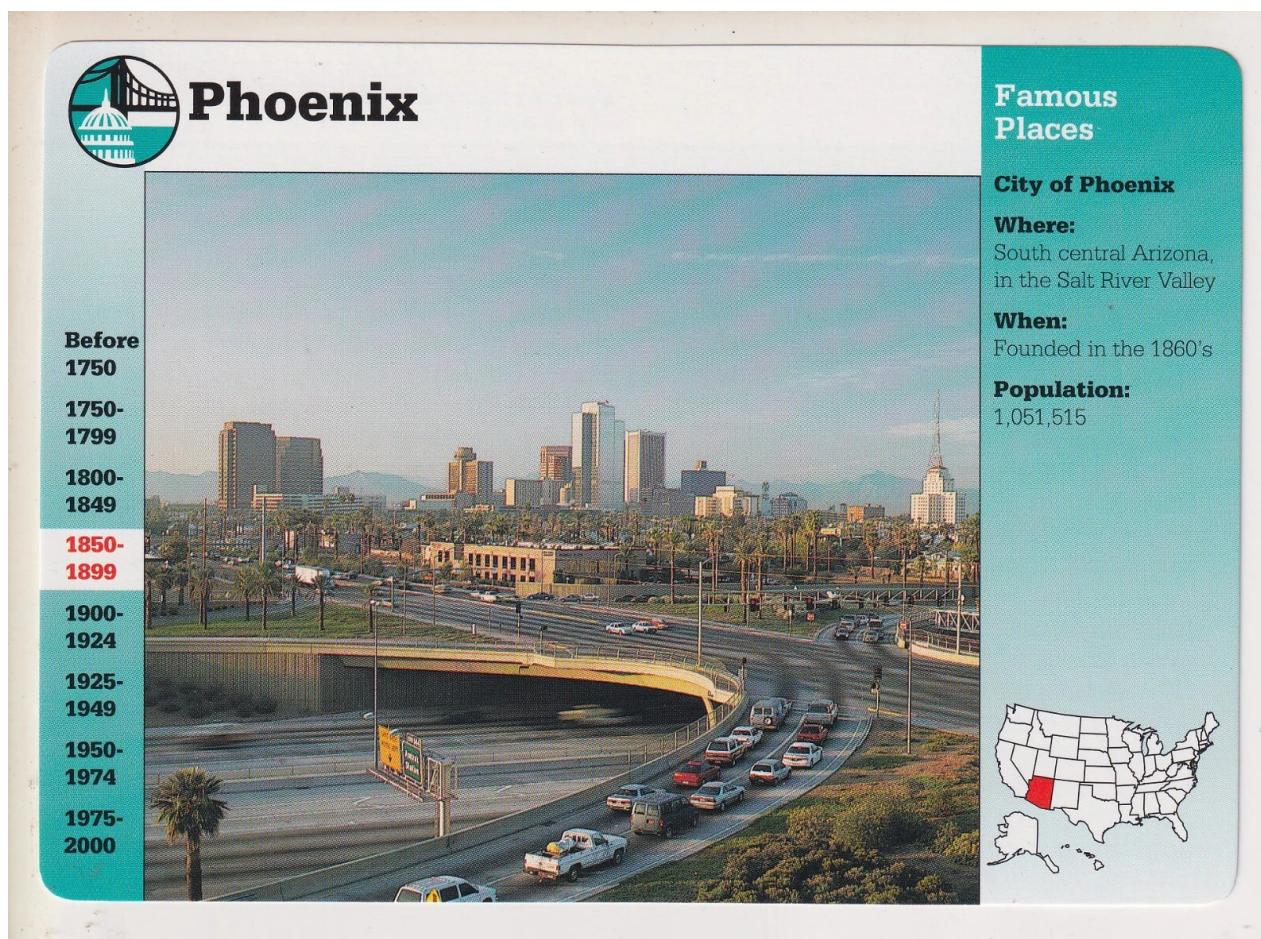


Figure 11: Phoenix city skyline 1995 (Grolier Story of American Card #29-4)

The political landscape remains as volatile as the summer heat. Governor Symington's bank fraud conviction joins a litany of scandals that have made Arizona synonymous with a particular kind of sunbelt corruption. Yet this same state that can't seem to keep its politicians out of federal court somehow managed to pass the nation's most progressive water conservation laws and complete one of the most ambitious water projects in American history. It's a duality that defines Phoenix: visionary and venal, planning centuries ahead while cutting corners in the present.

For law enforcement, Phoenix presents a unique puzzle. Traditional organised crime families operate alongside Mexican cartels whose influence grows with each passing year. The Don Bolles assassination still haunts local journalism, a reminder that in Phoenix, the lines between legitimate business, real estate speculation, and criminal enterprise have always been blurry. Street gangs compete for territory in neighbourhoods that didn't exist a generation ago, while white-collar criminals exploit the chaos of constant growth. The city's proximity to the Mexican border adds another layer of complexity, with drug trafficking routes running through the same desert that legitimate commerce and immigration traverse.

The city's physical form tells its own story. Master-planned communities sprawl across former citrus groves and cotton fields, connected by freeways that arrived late and controversially. The Deck Park Tunnel—Phoenix's answer to neighbourhood activists

who fought the Papago Freeway for decades—carries Interstate 10 beneath downtown, a compromise that satisfied no one completely but allowed the city to claim it had preserved its urban core. Sky Harbor Airport, with its new Terminal 4 and growing international service, and surrounded by development it once stood apart from, has become both economic engine and symbol of Phoenix's transformation from agricultural town to international city.

Environmental challenges that have always defined desert life now shape public policy. The summer heat that once emptied the city from May to October has been tamed by air conditioning but not conquered—scorching temperatures still define daily life in Phoenix to some extent for at least 6 months a year. Air quality struggles under the weight of millions of vehicles traversing a metropolitan area larger than some states. The monsoons still arrive each summer with their walls of dust, those spectacular haboobs that remind residents they live in a desert no matter how many swimming pools and golf courses suggest otherwise.

By summer 1997, Phoenix stands as a paradox: a booming metropolis built on shaky political foundations, a desert city that has secured its water future while struggling with air quality, a place where historic preservation efforts coexists with rapid development, and where the same week might bring a governor's criminal conviction and UFO sightings. For FBI agents operating here, it represents a unique challenge—a city whose very growth has created the conditions for both spectacular corruption and remarkable resilience. Phoenix in 1997 is America's urban future being beta-tested in the desert: diverse, dispersed, and still deciding what kind of city it wants to become when it finally stops expanding long enough to take stock of what it has built.



Figure 12: Flag of Phoenix, AZ

Phoenix Timeline

Ancient Period:

- c. 1-1450 AD: Hohokam civilisation develops extensive irrigation system
- c. 1450: Hohokam culture disappears mysteriously

Colonial Period:

- 1539: Marcos de Niza expedition, first Spanish exploration
- 1540-1542: Coronado expedition passes through Arizona
- 1687: Father Kino establishes southern Arizona missions
- 1821: Mexican independence; Arizona part of the Mexican state Sonora

American Period:

- 1848: Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo; Arizona becomes U.S. territory
- 1853: Gadsden Purchase completes Arizona boundaries
- 1863: Arizona Territory established
- 1865: Fort McDowell established on Verde River

Founding Phoenix:

- November 1867: Jack Swilling envisions Salt River Valley development
- December 1867: Swilling Irrigation Company begins canal excavation
- March 1868: First water diverted, crops planted
- May 1868: Phoenix officially recognized, first post office
- 1870: Official townsite selected and purchased
- 1871: Maricopa County created, Phoenix becomes county seat
- 1881: Phoenix incorporated as city; John T. Alsap first mayor
- 1887: Railroad reaches Phoenix area
- 1889: Phoenix becomes Arizona territorial capital

Statehood and Development:

- 1911: Roosevelt Dam completed
- February 14, 1912: Arizona becomes 48th state
- 1913: Phoenix adopts council-manager government
- 1920: First skyscraper (Heard Building) constructed
- 1929: Sky Harbor Airport established
- 1935: City purchases Sky Harbor

War and Growth:

- 1941: Luke Air Force Base, Thunderbird Field established
- 1941-1945: Major defence industry development
- 1950: Population reaches 106,818
- 1950s: Air conditioning adoption enables massive growth
- 1960: Population reaches 439,000; Sun City opens

Modern Development:

- 1963: Miranda v. Arizona case originates in Phoenix; establishes Miranda rights
- 1976: Don Bolles murdered investigating organised crime; leads to the Arizona Project
- 1987-1988: Governor Evan Mecham impeached and removed
- 1991: AZSCAM political corruption investigation
- 1990: Interstate 10 completed through downtown
- 1992: America West Arena opens
- 1997: Governor Fife Symington indicted, resigns

Epilogue: Phoenix Transformed (1997-2025)

The years following 1997 brought continued dramatic changes to the Valley of the Sun, though Phoenix residents could hardly have anticipated the scale of transformation ahead.

Political Evolution: Arizona's tradition of political scandal continued with the 2008 conviction of numerous public officials in federal corruption investigations. The state's controversial immigration law SB 1070 (2010) created national attention and federal court challenges, while Sheriff Joe Arpaio's Maricopa County operations became subjects of extensive federal civil rights investigations and eventual criminal conviction.

Demographic Transformation: Phoenix surpassed Philadelphia to become America's fifth-largest city by 2010, reaching 1.7 million residents. The metropolitan area exceeded 4.8 million by 2020, driven by continued retirement migration, technology sector growth, and Latino population expansion. The city became majority-minority by 2010, with Hispanic residents comprising over 40% of the population.

Economic Revolution: The Great Recession (2008-2012) devastated Phoenix's construction-dependent economy, with housing values declining over 50% and unemployment exceeding 10%. Recovery brought economic diversification, with major technology companies including Intel, Taiwan Semiconductor, and others establishing significant operations. Phoenix emerged as a major logistics and distribution centre, leveraging its central location and transportation infrastructure.

Criminal Enterprise Evolution: Traditional organised crime gave way to more sophisticated international operations. Mexican cartels established substantial presence, with Phoenix becoming a major hub for fentanyl trafficking by 2020. Human trafficking and cybercrime emerged as significant federal priorities, while political corruption investigations continued targeting state and local officials.

Urban Development: Light rail construction began in 2005, connecting Phoenix, Tempe, and Mesa by 2008 with continued expansion through 2025. Downtown Phoenix experienced significant revitalization with sports facilities (Chase Field, Footprint centre) and Arizona State University's downtown campus. Water security remained a constant concern, with new Colorado River agreements and expanded groundwater management.

Climate and Environment: Record heat events became more frequent, with Phoenix experiencing unprecedented temperatures exceeding 115°F (~46°C) for extended periods. Water conservation measures intensified, while urban heat island effects prompted new planning strategies and green infrastructure development.

By 2025, Phoenix stands as America's fifth-largest city and fastest-growing major metropolitan area—a testament to the vision that transformed a desert valley into one of the nation's most significant urban centres, though not without the challenges of rapid growth, criminal enterprise, and environmental sustainability that federal agents continue to address daily.